



Power game: Even though No. 2 Swiatek sailed through the weakest quarter of the draw, giving up just 14 games, she couldn't match Keys' gutsy game in the semifinal. GETTY IMAGES

average rose this season to 109 mph, six mph more than in 2024, despite mixing in plenty of kick serves. Earlier, Svitolina matched her husband Gael Monfils, who upset No. 4 Taylor Fritz, by taking out No. 4 Jasmine Paolini 2-6, 6-4, 6-0.

Meanwhile, No. 2 Swiatek sailed through the weakest quarter of the draw, giving up just 14 games in five matches. Only Maria Sharapova (9), Monica Seles (12), and Steffi Graf (13) have allowed fewer games before the AO semis. Swiatek's most impressive win, though the 6-1, 6-2 score didn't reflect it, came against tough-as-nails American and No. 8 seed Emma Navarro.

The 23-year-old had battled through three-set wins over Peyton Stearns, Wang Xiyu, three-time Major finalist Ons Jabeur, and crafty No. 9 seed Daria Kasatkina. Following her victory over Jabeur, she had the best quip of the tournament: "I love three sets. I love tennis so much. I can't

resist playing three sets."

In what *ESPN* analyst Mary Joe Fernandez called "the match of the tournament," Keys staved off a match point — down 6-5 in the deciding set — against Swiatek, and belted a forehand serve return that forced a backhand error from the Pole. Keys was so intently focused that she later said she didn't remember it — though Swiatek surely will. Two points later, the five-time Major champion blinked, double-faulting to set up a dramatic, 10-point match tiebreak.

Once again, Keys lived dangerously. She trailed by one or two points up to 8-7 for her opponent. Then she grabbed the last three points with an ace, unreturnable serve, and, ironically, an unforced error from Swiatek's forehand, her best shot, to seal a thrilling win. Relieved and happy, Keys bent down on her knees and cried.

"She pushed me when she needed to," said the dejected Swiatek, who has lost most often on hard courts to power hitters like Keys. She conceded Keys "was brave with her decisions" and "totally deserved to be in the final."

Sabalenka, going for a three-peat at the Australian Open and her fourth Major title, rampaged through the top half of the draw, except for a 6-2, 2-6, 6-3 quarterfinal win over solid-stroking Russian veteran and No. 27 seed Anastasia Pavlyuchenkova.

The eagerly anticipated contest between Sabalenka and No. 3 Coco Gauff never materialised. What happened? Gauff had entered the AO unbeaten at 9-0 this year and 22-2 since the end of the 2024 US Open. Almost inexplicably, her forehand and serve fell apart to the tune of 41 unforced errors and a disappointing 7-5, 6-4 defeat. Paula Badosa, who was ranked No. 2 in April 2022, has all the shots but, like Keys, sometimes got nervous on big points and occasions. Not this time. She blasted two aces in the last game to clinch the biggest win of her career.

Best of friends

In the semis, the Belarusian basher faced 11th seed Badosa. Best of friends, they often practise together, shop together, and make dancing videos together.

Sabalenka played as fiercely as the tiger tattooed on her forearm and stamped on her sneakers, devouring Badosa 6-4, 6-2, thanks to 32 winners, and just one double fault — her bugaboo until two years ago. After Sabalenka won the Brisbane tune-up event, Badosa told *ausopen.com*: "For me, what she improved the most is how she deals with emotions. She's a very emotional girl. That's why I empathise a lot with her. That's the big change she made in her game, also believing she can be the best, and she proved it."

Indeed, she had. Even though the Queen of Hard Courts was a solid betting favourite for the final, some observers, like Jessica Pegula, picked her compatriot. Fernandez recalled that after Keys beat Pegula in the Adelaide final two weeks earlier, Pegula said, "If she plays half as well as she played against me, she'll win the tournament."

Having Fratangelo in her corner under the liberalised coaching rule